out that Se-la was the only geographical feature between Tawang and Bomdila that could constitute a defensive locality. I described in some detail the environment of the pass. I knew the terrain, I said, because I had walked all over it before motor roads ever came to Kameng. I described the main tracks over and around Se-la Top, not all of which were correctly marked on the IV Corps sand model.'

Now Palit took over the briefing in its entirety. 'I could sense hostility from the corps staff, resenting outside interference on tactical matters, but Thapar gave me a look of encouragement and so also, surprisingly, did Sen. He seemed almost relieved that I had taken over. I pressed home the advantage.

'I strongly advocated holding the Se-la massif. I suggested that a brigade sector, later to be built up to two brigades, be established forthwith at Se-la–Senge. As more troops arrived and logistics permitted, a brigade sector could also be established at Bomdila to guard the approach from the north via the Lap Valley and Poshing-la… After some discussions on the map, COAS [Thapar] and GOC-in-C [Sen] agreed to my recommendations and the latter telephoned GOC 4 Division [Niranjan Prasad], who had reached Dirang by then, and ordered him to return to Se-la next morning and, because of my intimate knowledge of the terrain, advise the GOC regarding the layout of defences. The GOC-in-C Eastern Command readily agreed to this suggestion.'

In the history of modern warfare, it is doubtful if there are any generals at the top of a command pyramid who have displayed such collective incompetence as these two officers. Surely, by then, Thapar could see just how muddled Bogey Sen's thinking was, yet he refrained from doing anything about it. On the contrary, on the evening of 23 October, the chief decided to back Sen's decision to sack Niranjan Prasad on the grounds of cowardice. Given that the orders that Prasad had been forced to implement (post 11 October) originated from Thapar and Sen, the sacking of Prasad amounted to making him the scapegoat. But just as Prasad was probably guilty of not standing up and fighting in Tawang, the charge would apply even more to Bogey Sen. That Prasad had failed to instil some backbone into 7 Brigade was bad enough, worse, the GOC failed to grasp that for a tactical withdrawal to happen, there had to be a previously planned alternative. Else, a withdrawal would, sooner or later, become a panicky retreat.